

Valve Reality

THOSE OF YOU WHO KNOW ME, know that I am a HUGE Half-life fanboy, and unabashedly so. It's brought me tremendous joy over the years. I still remember playing Half-life for the first time in 1999 (it was released in 1998, but I only played it in 1999 on a friend's PC). I was blown away! This.... This is what gaming was supposed to be. Not pointless scrollers and silly shooters, but this, something immersive, something that gave you a story, made you feel like you were in a movie. A very pixelated movie, but a movie nonetheless!

When Half-life 2 released in 2004, I was buried nose deep in work at Digit, but I made time to play it. I'd stay late after everyone in the test centre had gone home, and sit on a powerful machine to enjoy it in all its glory. Often playing all through the night until people started coming back to work the next morning. My family was not pleased about that, to say the least. However, Half-life 2 did what HL1 had done, all over again, and revolutionised the single player shooter genre, and changed what we'd come to expect of it in the future.

While Half-life 1 was a lesson in story telling done right, Half-life 2 was a lesson in physics done right. Before it, game physics was something people didn't really want you to look at. Sure they'd send stuff clattering here and there after an explosion, but it wasn't realistic, as such, and therefore was always something in the background. What HL2 did was raise the bar so high, that they could afford to make physics the central focus of the game. In fact, you had to use physics to get past hurdles and obstacles and complete levels. Find a see-saw bridge, and you would need to use floatation devices to keep the bridge from see-sawing as you crossed over it. If you shot a box, it shattered, same for glass, and you could use heavy items to kill people, just as you would be able to in real life. Drop a car on a character's head in another game, and the car would pass right through them, or bounce off them, and in HL2, you'd get a gory splatter and very real world consequences. What Half-life 2 was, was a way for Valve to show off their source engine, and boy was it worth showing off!

So much emphasis on physics eventually resulted in dedicated physics processing units being introduced into computer architecture. Aegia's PhysX was one of the biggest at the

time, until NVIDIA bought them over, later in 2008. Today, all of the nice physics you see in games is because of dedicated physics processors on graphics cards, and all of that was set in motion by HL2!

Plus, Half-life 2 made the Steam distribution platform that we all know and love (or maybe hate) now. Steam really set the stage for PC gaming, and especially gave indie games the chance to shine. And, of course, it made Valve, very, very rich indeed. So great was the impact it had on people, that there are several gaming journalists online who still say it is the greatest FPS ever made, even more than a decade after it was released! Then we had to wait until 2006 and 2007 to get Episode 1 and Episode 2 of HL2, and that made the game even longer, and better, which we didn't think was even possible, to be honest.

Then, Gordon Freeman went missing from everyone's life. There was supposed to be an Episode 3 of the HL2 saga... it never came. Then it was rumoured that there would be no Episode 3, but a Half-life 3 game, and that never came. And for the last 12 years, nothing else came... and now, suddenly there's a new Half-life game releasing in 4 months time!

Am I going to get a new graphics card and VR gear just to be able to play the new HL game in March? You bet! And I've already started saving up for it. Based on the history of Half-life games alone, I think Half-life Alyx will do for VR what HL2 did for physics, and that's a very exciting prospect indeed. Valve's VR offering called Index is already getting some rave reviews from people in Canada and the US, despite what seems to be a slight design flaw in their controller which causes a significant number of them to have to be replaced! The Index itself is supposed to be very good, and offers the clearest VR screens thus far in headsets. This makes for a extremely immersive VR experience, and based on insider leaks about previews of Alyx that they have played, the game is a showcase of how VR should be done in games.

Valve seems to only bring out Half-life games when they need to push something huge on to us consumers, and while it does make them even more filthy rich... it's because their product is really that good! That's just Valve reality... **d**



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